



INDIAN DREAM

teams and players. He expressed hope that they will make an entry into the tournament next year with a new team.

S. Dakshinamoorthy, the Defenders' head coach, said, "As the hosts we were able to face the top clubs from around the world. This experience will motivate our players. Players from other clubs are very experienced, have undergone a lot of training and are playing in top-level European leagues. If this culture and professionalism is developed in our country, our players can also move higher."

The setbacks for the Indian side started with players not receiving permission from their departments for the tournament training sessions;

the Defenders came together just 15-20 days prior. "What's problematic in our system is receiving permission from the respective departments that they work for, due to which the camp started late," said Dakshinamoorthy.

Another major woe was when SV Guru Prasanth got injured while training in Bengaluru, a few days before the tournament. Angamuthu Ramaswamy, another outside hitter, felt that the injury scare was a point of concern for the team but hoped the team would bounce back.

Adding a fresh perspective to the Defenders' side was the inclusion of Australian outside hitter Max Senica. "We watched the opposition very excitedly. Max saw this and called a

All hail the champion: Sir Sicoma Perugia won the FIVB Men's Volleyball Club World Championship after beating Itambe Minas 25-13, 25-21, 25-19. SUDHAKARAJAIN

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meeting. He told us that we are not their fans and should not react like that when we see them since we will be competing against them. These words stuck with me," said Angamuthu, while recalling how Max expected them to stay grounded.

The home team enjoyed the support of fans from neighbouring States as well. Amidst the white placards and flags of the Ahmedabad team was a red banner from Chembada, the official fan club of its PVL rivals, the Calicut Heroes. The banner read — 'India's pride at World Volley Club Champs.'

Among the other five teams, two players got the most cheers from the Indian audience — Sunbirds' famed London Olympics 2012 winner Dmitry Muserskiy, who played opposite hitter, and Perugia's captain, Wilfredo Leon, who was benched for the entire tournament due to an injury.

Pool A saw Perugia comfortably top the table, while in Pool B, all the teams lost at least one match. The opening match saw the clash of the two debutants — Halkbank and Sunbirds — in which the latter pipped the former 25-23, 25-23, 25-16 after staying neck-and-neck in